

Latvia



Latvia lies on the east coast of the Baltic Sea. Like its Baltic neighbors, it regained independence from Moscow in 1991, and joined the EU and NATO in 2004.



GEOGRAPHY

A flat coastal plain which is deeply indented by the Gulf of Riga. Poor drainage creates many bogs and swamps in the forested interior.



CLIMATE

Temperate, with warm summers and cold winters. There is steady rainfall throughout the year.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Latvians make up just over half of the population and are mostly Lutheran. They have been officially favored by the state since 1991 over the largely Orthodox Christian Russian minority. Latvian was declared the only official language in 2000 and has been used exclusively in schools since 2004. This discrimination has strained relations with neighboring Russia. Women enjoy full equality. The divorce rate is high.



THE ECONOMY

Services sector now accounts for over 70% of GDP. EU's fastest-growing economy in 2004–2006. High inflation has delayed prospect of joining euro. Global credit crunch brought Latvia to verge of bankruptcy in 2008: banks were bailed out and severe recession followed.



INSIGHT: Ethnic Latvians are outnumbered by Russians in Riga



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Latvia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Riga

POPULATION: 2.25 million

TOTAL AREA: 24,938 sq. miles
(64,589 sq. km)

DENSITY: 90 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Latvian*, Russian

RELIGIONS: Lutheran 55%, Catholic 24%, other 12%, Orthodox Christian 9%

ETHNIC MIX: Latvian 59%, Russian 29%, Belarussian 4%, Ukrainian 3%, Polish 3%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Lats = 100 santimi